

Then he threw open the Vidhana Soudha to the public and announced, just like any elected leader, that he would be holding a janata darshan every alternate day.

The public thronged the secretariat as Thakur met 1,500 people from across the state in just four janata darshans. Accompanied by officials including the state police chief K.R. Srinivasan in one meeting, Thakur gave a patient hearing to the visitors—the disabled, sickly, unemployed and even some blind people. But the darshans had their own share of embarrassing moments: a young man from Maddur attempted to kill himself in front of the governor; an asthma patient from Mandya district, waiting to meet Thakur, collapsed and died on the way to the hospital.

Politicians, cutting across party lines, however, applauded the 80-year-old governor's sincerity. Senior Congress leader R.V. Deshpande says, "This is a pro-active governor who has sought to work from both the Vidhana Soudha and the Raj Bhavan despite his advanced age." Even BJP's B.S. Yediyurappa, who would have been chief minister if JD(s) had honoured the power-sharing pact, admires Thakur's willingness to meet politicians from across the board. "We only hope that he pushes for early polls in the state," says Yediyurappa, hoping to gain from a sympathy wave for BJP.

It's evident that the governor takes the state of development in Bangalore very seriously. He has called a meeting of some top Bangalore agencies like Bangalore Development Authority, Bangalore City Corporation, Bangalore Metro Rail, the city police and the Bangalore Metropolitan Transport Corporation on October 27.

In his guest house in Mysore, when some activists, who are opposing a 1,000 MW power project in Chamalapura, sought 20 minutes with the governor to explain their opposition, Thakur shot back, "Why just 20 minutes, I will give you an hour in my office in Bangalore." He is learning to



JILTED: Yediyurappa (left), ditched by Kumaraswamy, hopes the governor will call early polls

talk like a popular chief minister.

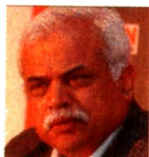
The 12-year-old Rs 3,200-crore Bangalore-Mysore infrastructure corridor project—India's first expressway and integrated township project spanning 20,000-odd acres between the two cities—is likely to move forward again following the project promoter Ashok Kheny's hour-long meeting with the governor on October 17. "We are hoping that the governor will step in and pave the way for the speedy completion of the project," says Kheny, who was singularly targeted by Kumaraswamy and his father Deve Gowda.

The governor has also been making some right noises from time to time: he has called for maintenance of peace and harmony during the November/December Shobha Yatra and the Datta Peetha Jayanthi celebrations in Chikmagalur, an issue over which JD(s) and the Congress have been fighting a bitter battle with BJP. The issue relates to worship at a shrine in the Bababudangiri hills, which is claimed by both Muslims and Hindus. BJP wants to convert this into an Ayodhya of the south. Thakur has said that the Government would stand by the Constitution and ensure that the

Datta Jayanthi is held peacefully. BJP legislator C.T. Ravi says the Vishwa Hindu Parishad and the Bajrang Dal, with the support of BJP, would carry out its Datta Jayanthi campaign in accordance with the orders of the state high court and the Supreme Court.

With political parties busy with their agenda, the state of governance is in a flux right now even with the governor trying his best to toggle dual responsibilities. Thakur's chamber, Cauvery, at the Raj Bhavan is streaming with people—politicians, business leaders, academicians, police officers and old political friends from his home state Bihar. Several key officials from the Government including Information Technology Secretary M.N. Vidyashankar, Urban Development Senior Secretary K. Jothiramalingam and state Advocate General Uday Holla have already called on the governor. Legislators from all political parties have also met him for one-on-one discussions. Prominent among them are U.T. Khader from Congress and C.T. Ravi and Abhay Patil from BJP. "We are doing our best to ensure that the office of the governor is accessible to the public," says Subramaniam.

As Thakur puts it, "We have to be available to the people and see what best can be done." This is one governor who is defying his age and health to reach out to the wider world, just like his Bharat Scouts and Guides days, and make the best use of the twin offices of the chief minister and the Raj Bhavan.



"This is a proactive governor who has chosen to work from both Vidhana Soudha and Raj Bhavan."

R.V. DESHPANDE, CONGRESS LEADER